

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Baristas and Cafe Staff English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For Baristas, cafe counter staff, and coffee pickup staff.

All orders, prices, recipes, promotions, and incidents are fictional language practice, not barista certification, allergen-control training, health advice, or equipment-maintenance instruction. Recipes and terminology vary by cafe. Use current workplace information and refer suitability or equipment questions to the designated lead. This course focuses on counter and coffee-bar exchanges, not hospitality management.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Taking a precise drink order

Clarify a familiar word that can describe several order details.

02 Comparing drinks without overclaiming

Explain this cafe's options without presenting a universal recipe.

03 Clarifying milk, syrup, and allergy questions

Clarify sweetness and allergy questions as separate issues.

04 Managing the queue and pickup

Use a second identifier when names are duplicated.

05 Handling remakes and mistaken labels

Acknowledge the error and confirm the replacement details.

06 Discussing coffee beans for home

Distinguish grind requirements and flavor descriptions from assumptions.

07 Explaining counter prices and sold-out items

State included items and additional charges before the customer commits.

08 Handing over the bar and till

Hand over orders, supplies, and a till question without merging them.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop to choose a vocabulary, grammar, role-play, or new-dialogue activity.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Taking a precise drink order

Clarify a familiar word that can describe several order details.

CASE

A customer says 'a regular latte.' This cafe uses regular for its middle size, but the customer might mean caffeinated coffee or the usual milk. No drink has been made. Clarify size, hot or iced, and coffee choice separately.

Teach this move

Ask one specification at a time. Decaf describes coffee, not milk or sweetness, and doesn't mean guaranteed zero caffeine.

Vocabulary to check: espresso, shot, decaf, dine in.

Model response

When you say regular, do you mean our middle size or caffeinated coffee? I'll check those separately so I enter the right drink. Would you like the latte hot or iced, and which milk would you prefer? Once those details are clear, I'll repeat the full order before sending it to the bar.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The check separates size from coffee choice.

Second-round challenge

The customer says 'the normal one' about milk. Ask for the actual milk choice.

Language-check answers

1. C - size Correct. The customer uses 'middle' to identify the size.
2. D - coffee with most caffeine removed Correct. Decaffeination removes most caffeine without guaranteeing complete absence.

05 · Conversations

1. Regular needs three checks - The ambiguous latte order from the case.
2. A shot is not a bigger cup - A customer asks what an extra-shot option changes.
3. Leaving room is an amount request - A customer clarifies space in a filter-coffee cup.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Hot order, iced label

A customer orders a small hot decaf latte. Before payment, the screen shows small iced decaf latte. Milk choice is correct.

Role A: Barista: read the screen and correct temperature style.

Role B: Customer: confirm hot, not iced; keep the other choices.

Possible opening: I have iced on the screen, but I heard hot. Which did you want?

Success checks

- Obtain hot or iced explicitly.
- Keep decaf and size unchanged.
- Read back the corrected order.

Add a complication: The customer says 'same as before,' but the previous order isn't visible.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Comparing drinks without overclaiming

Explain this cafe's options without presenting a universal recipe.

CASE

In this fictional cafe, the small latte and small cappuccino both contain the same espresso serving. The cappuccino has more foam; the latte has more liquid milk. The customer wants less foam, not more caffeine. Compare the two using those facts.

Teach this move

Ask whether 'strong' means coffee flavor, less milk, or caffeine. Local recipe facts support a comparison; they don't establish precise caffeine totals.

Vocabulary to check: latte, cappuccino, Americano, filter coffee.

Model response

In our small drinks, both choices use the same espresso serving. The cappuccino has more foam, while the latte has more liquid milk. Since you're asking for less foam rather than more coffee, the latte sounds closer to that preference. I wouldn't use how strong it tastes as an exact measure of caffeine.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision replaces an unsupported inference with a bounded comparison.

Second-round challenge

The customer asks whether a stronger taste guarantees more caffeine. Explain the limit.

Language-check answers

1. A - latte Correct. This matches the two milk drinks in the stated recipe comparison.
2. B - but Correct. 'But' contrasts two compatible facts.

05 • Conversations

1. Less foam, not more coffee - The small-drink comparison in the case.
2. An Americano is not filter coffee - A customer wants the brewed-coffee option on the menu.
3. Strong can mean flavor - A barista clarifies a taste preference without caffeine claims.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Foam is the deciding factor

The menu offers two small milk drinks with the same stated espresso serving. One is described as having more foam. The customer wants that texture.

Role A: Barista: compare foam without promising caffeine content.

Role B: Customer: choose the foamier option after clarification.

Possible opening: Are you asking about the foam layer or the coffee amount?

Success checks

- Clarify lighter.
- Use this cafe's recipe descriptions.
- Read back the chosen drink.

Add a complication: The customer uses 'lighter' to mean airy texture, not lower caffeine.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Clarifying milk, syrup, and allergy questions

Clarify sweetness and allergy questions as separate issues.

CASE

A customer reports a milk allergy and asks for an oat latte without vanilla syrup. The barista knows oat drink is available but has not checked its current ingredients or shared-equipment arrangements. No claim of suitability can be made from the drink name.

Teach this move

No syrup doesn't necessarily mean no added sweetener in other ingredients. A plant-based name doesn't resolve all ingredient or cross-contact questions.

Vocabulary to check: milk alternative, syrup, sweetened, shared equipment.

Model response

I can note oat drink and no vanilla syrup, but those changes don't by themselves establish suitability for your milk allergy. I need to check the current product information and ask our lead about shared equipment. Let's leave the drink unmade while we get those details, so you can decide with accurate information.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised response doesn't confuse an order preference with suitability.

Second-round challenge

A colleague says plant-based always means suitable. Explain what that label doesn't establish.

Language-check answers

1. C - omit the vanilla syrup Correct. This removes only the requested vanilla component.
2. D - still need to be Correct. Omitting syrup doesn't establish every component's ingredients.

05 • Conversations

1. Oat is a choice, not a guarantee - The oat-latte question from the case.
2. No syrup doesn't describe the carton - A customer clarifies what they mean by less sweet.
3. Checking the actual product - A barista asks the lead about a customer's ingredient question.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A syrup is already in the base

A seasonal drink uses a premixed base that includes vanilla. The customer wants that drink with no vanilla. The lead confirms vanilla cannot be removed from this batch. A plain hot latte is available; the lead has checked its current ingredients and confirmed they contain no vanilla. It does not use the seasonal base. This ingredient check does not establish allergy suitability or rule out cross-contact.

Role A: Barista: explain the premixed base's limit and offer the plain hot latte as a different recipe, not an allergy-safe guarantee.

Role B: Customer: ask whether omitting a final syrup addition removes vanilla already in the base.

Possible opening: The base already contains vanilla; leaving out an extra addition wouldn't remove it.

Success checks

- Identify the premixed component.
- Avoid promising removal from the existing base.
- Ask whether the customer wants the plain hot latte without making an allergy-safety guarantee.

Add a complication: The customer thought 'no syrup' would change the entire recipe.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Managing the queue and pickup

Use a second identifier when names are duplicated.

CASE

Two customers named Sam have orders. Ticket 64 is a small hot latte and is complete. Ticket 67 is a large iced decaf latte and is in progress. The customer collecting 67 hears 'Sam' and reaches for 64. Clarify using ticket and drink details.

Teach this move

A pickup name may not be unique. Check drink specifications or the ticket number without requesting unrelated personal details.

Vocabulary to check: order ticket, pickup name, mobile order, order queue.

Model response

Are you collecting ticket sixty-seven, the large iced decaf latte? This completed drink is a small hot latte on sixty-four for another Sam. Your order is still in progress. I'll use the ticket number as well as the name when I call it, so the two orders don't get mixed up.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The ticket and drink distinguish customers with the same name.

Second-round challenge

The label is partly hidden. Check the ticket rather than guessing from the name.

Language-check answers

1. D - in progress Correct. The iced decaf order is being prepared.
2. B - what your ticket number is Correct. The subject precedes its verb in this embedded question.

05 • Conversations

1. Two Sams at the counter - The duplicated pickup name in the case.
2. Received doesn't mean ready - A customer interprets a mobile confirmation.
3. A courier has a different number - A counter worker resolves a pickup-identifier mismatch.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Two out of three drinks ready

A customer ordered three drinks on ticket 48. Two are complete; the decaf is pending. The customer asks whether the whole order is ready.

Role A: Barista: state partial progress and offer grouped collection.

Role B: Customer: prefer to collect all three together.

Possible opening: Two drinks are ready; the decaf is still being prepared.

Success checks

- Identify the missing drink.
- Confirm grouped collection.
- Call the whole order only when complete.

Add a complication: A friend reaches for the two cups without knowing one drink remains.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handling remakes and mistaken labels

Acknowledge the error and confirm the replacement details.

CASE

Ticket 22 requests a small iced latte with no syrup, but the cup label says hot vanilla latte. The customer hasn't collected it. A replacement is available; its wait hasn't been checked. Correct the mismatch without claiming a refund or a serving time.

Teach this move

Distinguish an incorrect label from a verified ingredient claim. The correct ticket supplies the requested drink, while the bar checks what happened.

Vocabulary to check: remake, cup label, order modifier, texture.

Model response

The cup label doesn't match your ticket: you ordered a small iced latte with no syrup, but this label says hot vanilla. I'm sorry for that mix-up. I'll request a fresh drink with your confirmed details and check the wait before giving you an estimate. Is the original order still what you'd like?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The response resolves the mismatch before handing over the cup.

Second-round challenge

The bar offers a different size. Check whether the customer wants that change rather than assuming.

Language-check answers

1. B - doesn't match Correct. This identifies the observed inconsistency between records.
2. B - requested Correct. Requesting a remake precedes its completion.

05 • Conversations

1. The label contradicts the ticket - The uncollected drink on ticket 22 from the case.
2. A taste complaint needs a question - A barista clarifies a drink concern without diagnosing the preparation.
3. A complaint about texture - A customer explains that foam, not coffee strength, is the issue.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Wrong pickup, not wrong recipe

A customer's ticket is 18, but they are holding unconsumed drink 81. Both names are Alex. The customer's drink is still at the bar.

Role A: Barista: identify the mismatch and consult the lead about the wrongly collected drink.

Role B: Customer: confirm ticket 18 and ask for the correct drink.

Possible opening: Let's compare the full ticket number before discussing a recipe change.

Success checks

- Distinguish pickup error from recipe error.
- Locate the correct order.
- Refer handling of the collected drink to workplace practice without inventing steps.

Add a complication: The customer asks you to put drink 81 back on the pickup shelf.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Discussing coffee beans for home

Distinguish grind requirements and flavor descriptions from assumptions.

CASE

A customer buys a gift bag and asks for 'normal ground.' They don't know the recipient's brewer. This cafe sells the same coffee whole or ground. Grinding cannot be undone. The package's 'hazelnut' note describes flavor, not an ingredient statement.

Teach this move

A tasting note doesn't prove an ingredient is present or absent. Ask about the brewer; don't prescribe an unsupported grind when the equipment is unknown.

Vocabulary to check: whole bean, grind size, roast date, tasting notes.

Model response

Could you tell me what kind of brewer the recipient uses? There isn't one grind described as normal for every brewer, and grinding can't be undone. We can leave this bag whole while you check. Also, the hazelnut tasting note describes a flavor impression; it isn't the ingredient information for an allergy question.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The question avoids an irreversible change based on an undefined request.

Second-round challenge

The customer asks whether 'hazelnut notes' guarantees an ingredient is absent. Refer to actual product information.

Language-check answers

1. D - whole Correct. Whole beans preserve the later choice of grinding.
2. B - roasted Correct. The term names the roasting event's date.

05 • Conversations

1. Normal ground for an unknown brewer - The gift-bag purchase from the case.

2. A roast date is not a purchase date - A customer compares a bag's roast date with the purchase date and asks about its printed storage guidance. No universal freshness guarantee is established.

3. A description, not an ingredient promise - A barista explains a coffee's chocolate tasting note.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Grinding request after checkout

A customer bought whole beans but now requests grinding. They say 'for a press' but mean either a French press or an espresso device. The bag has not been opened by staff.

Role A: Barista: ask which brewer they actually own.

Role B: Customer: you mean a French press with a plunger; explain when asked.

Possible opening: When you say press, which type of brewer do you mean?

Success checks

- Obtain a concrete brewer description.
- Repeat the understood equipment type.
- Check the cafe's grinding option before changing the product.

Add a complication: The customer calls both devices a coffee machine.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Explaining counter prices and sold-out items

State included items and additional charges before the customer commits.

CASE

A fictional cafe lists a latte at \$4, an oat-drink upcharge of \$0.50, and a pastry at \$3. The \$6 combo includes a standard latte and pastry; the oat upcharge still applies. Explain \$6.50 for that combo, versus \$7.50 separately, before payment.

Teach this move

An offer name doesn't specify every condition. Explain this fictional cafe's prices without implying all cafes charge the same way.

Vocabulary to check: upcharge, combo, loyalty reward, sold out.

Model response

The standard latte-and-pastry combo is six dollars. Your oat-drink choice adds fifty cents, so that combination is six fifty. Bought separately, the four-dollar latte, fifty-cent change, and three-dollar pastry would total seven fifty. The combo saves one dollar for these items; shall I enter that option with the oat choice?

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The customer hears the complete selected-item price.

Second-round challenge

The selected pastry sells out before payment. Ask whether the customer wants the remaining pastry; don't substitute silently.

Language-check answers

1. D - six fifty Correct. Six dollars plus fifty cents is six fifty.
2. A - instead Correct. 'Instead' offers the plain pastry as a substitute.

05 · Conversations

1. The upcharge remains in the combo - The fictional combo prices from the case.
2. A sold-out pastry is a choice point - A counter worker asks before substituting a pastry.
3. A reward has a specific condition - A fictional reward covers a standard filter coffee, not all drinks.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 • Say it: second scenario | A larger cup falls outside an offer

The fictional \$5 combo includes a small filter coffee and a plain pastry. A large coffee costs \$4 separately; the pastry costs \$3. No large-drink combo is listed.

Role A: Counter worker: explain the actual included size.

Role B: Customer: decide between the small combo and \$7 separate items.

Possible opening: The five-dollar combo uses the small coffee; would that size work for you?

Success checks

- Name the included size.
- State both complete choices.
- Get a choice before payment.

Add a complication: The customer assumes the large upgrade is free.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Handing over the bar and till

Hand over orders, supplies, and a till question without merging them.

CASE

At 2:00, ticket 108's coffee is complete but its tea is pending. Large takeaway lids are unavailable, though small lids remain. The outgoing worker counted the till, but the lead's reconciliation is pending. Assign the tea and stock follow-up without calling the till signed off.

Teach this move

Counting cash is not the same as reconciling it with records. Explain the specific stockout so the next worker doesn't assume every size is unavailable.

Vocabulary to check: till, cash float, reconciliation, stockout.

Model response

Ticket one-oh-eight still needs its tea; the coffee is complete. Large takeaway lids are out, but small lids remain. Can you take the tea order and confirm the large-lid situation with the lead? I've counted the till, but reconciliation isn't complete. I'll stay responsible for that review until the lead takes it.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The incoming worker can identify separate actions.

Second-round challenge

A coworker says the till 'looks about right.' Keep the unresolved record comparison explicit.

Language-check answers

1. D - large lids only Correct. Only large takeaway lids are reported unavailable.
2. A - still pending Correct. Counting alone doesn't complete the required comparison.

05 • Conversations

1. One tea, one stockout, one review - The 2:00 handover from the case.
2. A float is not today's takings - A new counter worker clarifies the till count.
3. Which cup size is actually missing? - A barista clarifies a supply shortage before updating the counter.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A pickup has no completion mark

Ticket 120 shows two coffees but no collection status. The cups aren't on the shelf. The outgoing worker didn't witness pickup; the lead can check the order history.

Role A: Outgoing worker: report what you know and don't know.

Role B: Incoming worker: accept the status check without marking collected from appearance alone.

Possible opening: I can't confirm whether ticket 120 was collected.

Success checks

- Separate shelf observation from pickup confirmation.
- Identify ticket 120.
- Assign the check and preserve uncertain status.

Add a complication: A colleague assumes an empty shelf proves collection.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and switches roles and repeats the exchange. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All orders, prices, recipes, promotions, and incidents are fictional language practice, not barista certification, allergen-control training, health advice, or equipment-maintenance instruction. Recipes and terminology vary by cafe. Use current workplace information and refer suitability or equipment questions to the designated lead. This course focuses on counter and coffee-bar exchanges, not hospitality management.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook: Food and Beverage Serving and Related Workers

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/food-preparation-and-serving/food-and-beverage-serving-and-related-workers.htm>

O*NET OnLine: Baristas

<https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/35-3023.01>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.